

MKTG20006: Brand Management

GROUP ASSIGNMENT

BRAND ANALYSIS: SUBWAY

Aaron - Thursday 2 pm

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Executive Summary

This report examines Subway's brand performance using **Keller's Customer-Based Brand Equity (CBBE) model**, based on primary research data and competitor analysis. The brand was evaluated across four CBBE stages: **salience, significance, response, and resonance**.

The group survey's findings show that Subway has strong aided brand awareness with 100% logo recognition and 90% past experience but weak unaided brand recall and limited tagline recognition. While Subway is associated with freshness, health, and customization, inconsistencies in product quality and service across brands undermine the brand's credibility.

In the response stage, past scandals and inconsistent communications have damaged consumer trust, and emotional engagement remains low. In the resonance stage, loyalty is driven more by convenience than true attachment, indicating weak attitudinal loyalty and community engagement.

We identified two key opportunities. First, Subway should enhance brand resonance through personalized and gamified loyalty programs and foster a sense of community through user-generated content and social activities. Second, Subway should ensure brand consistency across all stores through uniform employee training, internal audits, and updated digital service capabilities to enhance brand meaning. In short, closing these gaps will enable Subway to better align its brand promise with the customer experience and enhance long-term equity.

Introduction

Subway is a globally renowned fast food restaurant chain that specializes in submarine sandwiches and salads. The brand was founded in 1965 by Fred DeLuca and Peter Buck in Bridgeport, Connecticut with a simple vision: to **deliver fresh, high-quality food quickly and affordably** (Gu, 2020). Today, Subway has more than 41,000 restaurants in more than 100 countries, making it the largest single-brand restaurant chain in the world (Gu, 2020). From a financial perspective, Subway is a private company with estimated annual revenues of approximately \$11 million (Gu, 2020). While Subway does not publicly disclose detailed financial statements, its operating model centered on low franchise investment requirements and a flexible store format has enabled it to achieve rapid global expansion. Notably, Subway's franchise costs are much lower than those of major competitors such as McDonald's—franchise costs range from \$78,600 to \$238,300, while McDonald's costs range from \$950,200 to \$1.8 million, making Subway extremely attractive to new investors (Pitta, 2010). In terms of competition, Subway positions itself among the top fast food chains in the world, facing stiff competition from McDonald's, Burger King, Wendy's, and Domino's. While McDonald's leads in global market share, Subway's core differentiation is to offer **healthier, customizable alternatives, such as low-fat sandwiches and salads, to appeal to health-conscious consumers** (Gu, 2020; Pitta, 2010). This **positioning** is also supported by marketing strategies that emphasize freshness, such as the iconic Jared Fogle advertising campaign, which emphasized weight loss through Subway meals (Pitta, 2010). Its slogan, "Eat Fresh," captures the brand's commitment to providing nutritious, customizable meals in a fast, friendly environment. By openly displaying ingredients and allowing for full customization, Subway empowers consumers to take control of their food, a departure from the traditional fast food model centered around pre-set meals (Gu, 2020). Thus, this leads to

the following positioning statement: **for health-conscious, busy consumers seeking affordable, customizable meals, Subway offers freshly prepared sandwiches and salads, providing a nutritious alternative to fast food with a transparent, customer-oriented service.**

Brand analysis using CBBE model:

The Customer-Based Brand Equity (CBBE) pyramid developed by Keller (1993) emphasizes that a brand's value lies in how customers perceive, feel, and respond to it.

Stage 1: Brand Salience

The foundation of the CBBE pyramid is **brand salience**, which refers to how easily and frequently consumers recognize and recall a brand. This is the crucial first step in building customer brand assets. As Papirfly (2019) notes, this fundamental level supports the rest of the pyramid. If people don't know the brand, they will have difficulty forming opinions or perceptions about it. Therefore, to build a strong relationship with consumers, it is important for enterprises to enhance customers' awareness of the brand. The awareness of the brand refers to how easily consumers **recognise** or **recall** a brand. **Brand recognition** refers to consumers' ability to confirm prior exposure to a brand when given a cue (Keller, 2013), and **brand recall** refers to consumers' ability to retrieve a brand from memory when given a product category or usage situation (Keller, 2013). To assess Subway's salience, the group designed and distributed a survey targeting general brand awareness, logo recognition, slogan familiarity, and purchase frequency. The results are summarized in the following visualisations.

Figure 1

4. Which of the following brands have you heard of?

20 responses

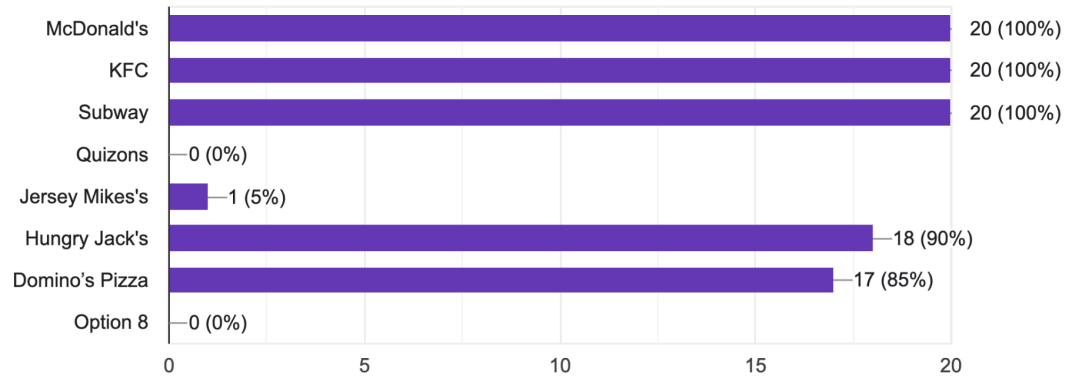


Figure 2

Which of these brands can you recognize based on their logo?

20 responses

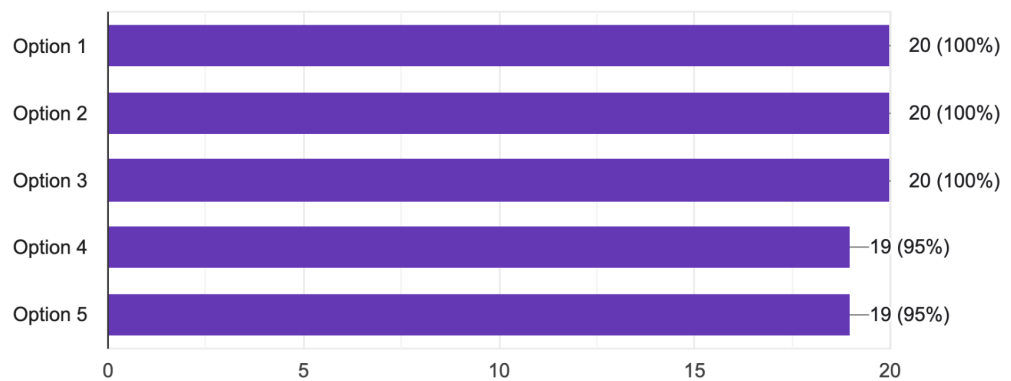


Figure 3

When you think of fast food sandwich or sub brands, which ones come to mind?

19 responses

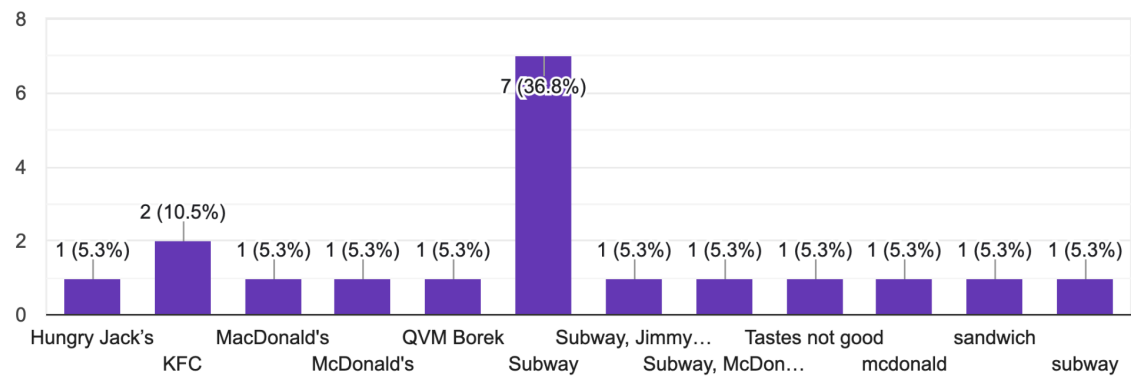


Figure 4

Have you ever eaten at Subway?

20 responses

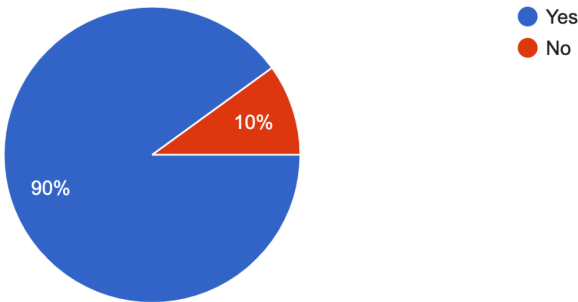
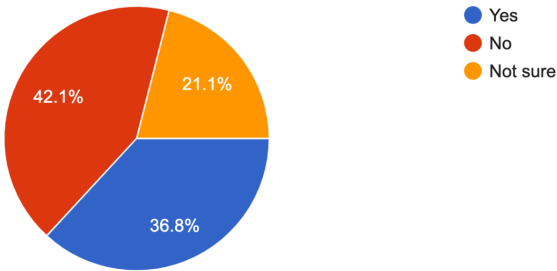


Figure 5

Have you ever seen or heard Subway's slogan, "Eat Fresh"?

19 responses



The survey results indicate that 100% of the participants can recognise Subway, and 90% of them have eaten Subway, showing a strong **aided brand recall**. However, **unaided recall is less dominant**, with just over 50% respondents having Subway as a top-of-mind fast food sandwich brand, suggesting that while the brand is well-known, competitors possibly have stronger top-of-mind preference. Regarding the Subway's slogan, only 36.8% of respondents responded have seen or heard the "Eat Fresh" slogan.

In terms of the influence of Subway's logo and name on Consumer **Recognition**, a report established in 2023 by Enterprise Apps Today suggests Subway was named one of the top 10 fast-food restaurant chains in the U.S. with an **89% brand awareness rate** (Enterprise Apps Today, 2023). Subway demonstrates strong performance in brand salience in the CBBE pyramid (Frampton, 2020). Studies indicate that Subway's logo and brand elements are highly recognizable, with brand recognition exceeding 90% in consumer studies (Crawford, 2025). The visual identity, for example, the color palette, font, and design, plays a significant role in triggering consumers' memory, and reinforcing brand salience. (Romaniuk & Sharp, 2004)

Stage 2: Brand Meaning

According to the customer purchase journey, once customers become aware of the brand, they seek information about its products. The second level of the pyramid is divided into Brand Performance and Imagery, which focuses on the functional aspects of the product or service. It examines how well the brand meets customers' basic needs in areas such as product features, reliability, service quality, design, and price.

2.1 Brand Performance

2.1.1 Primary Characteristics and Features

Subway positions itself as a fresh and healthy alternative in the quick-service restaurant (QSR) market (Brown, 2023). The ingredient tables, menus, and comparisons with other competitors in Appendix E, demonstrates that Subway provides *a wider variety of breads, proteins, and vegetables*.

2.1.2 Product Reliability

Product Reliability refers to consistency of product's quality that meets customer expectations. As a global franchise enterprise, Subway has generally maintained consistency in its menu and processes. However, due to the differences in franchise management, the quality varies from place to place. Customer reviews frequently mention inconsistent portion sizes and food presentation. According to Yelp and Google Reviews, some outlets receive lower ratings due to poor cleanliness or stale ingredients. For example, one review of a Subway location in Armidale, New South Wales, described the outlet as "scruffy" and noted the use of "stale ingredients" (W, 2016). Some of the common complaints also include sticky floors, filthy surfaces, and unpleasant odors which impact its brand image (Wells, 2024). Moreover, nearly half of all customer complaints are related to food quality and freshness, and over 30% are about order accuracy (Wells, 2024). These issues suggest that Subway needs to improve quality control and standardize training to protect brand integrity.

2.1.3 Service Effectiveness, Efficiency

According to the July 2020 UK Customer Satisfaction Index, Subway was ranked as the top quick-service restaurant and placed sixth overall among 271 organizations, indicating a high level of service effectiveness in meeting customer expectations (QSR Media UK, 2020).

However, customer satisfaction varies by location. Operational analyses have identified inefficiencies such as long queues and delays in service, highlighting the need for enhanced consistent employee training and process improvements (Desklib, n.d.-a).

In conclusion, Subway's brand performance is well aligned with its positioning as a fresh and health-conscious fast-food brand. Its menu variety, customization options, and affordability contribute positively to brand performance. **However, inconsistencies across franchises and variable service quality pose performance challenges.**

2.2 Brand Imagery

Brand imagery reflects the intangible, emotional, and symbolic associations that consumers attach to a brand (Keller, 2013). It includes how customers perceive themselves using the brand, the personality the brand represents.

Subway Brand Imagery

Imagery Element	Subway's Positioning
Brand Personality	Fresh, convenient, customizable
User Imagery	Health-conscious individuals, athletes
Usage Imagery	Quick & healthy meals, post-gym meal, healthy snack

While Subway shares **points of parity** such as quick offering, targeting people who want casual food with its common competitors (KFC, McDonald's). Its **points of differences, such**

as health-conscious and customizable characteristics, leave a unique placement in health - conscious consumers' minds since its differentiation also contributes to its recognition level when people are given usage situations. Therefore, Subway has successfully positioned itself as a functional and health-oriented fast-food brand.

Stage 3: Brand Response

1. Consumer Judgements

The next stage of the CBBE model is **Brand Response**, which is indicative of consumers' evaluations of a brand's imagery and performance (Keller, 2000). One component of this is consumer **judgments**, such as the perceived quality, credibility and superiority of the brand.

Subway's brand credibility significantly diminished when Jared Fogle was selected as a brand ambassador. Through the implementation of Jared Fogle's weight loss narrative, in which he lost 245 pounds by consuming two subway sandwiches a day, Subway constructed its brand image to resonate with the everyday, health-conscious consumer (*Former Subway spokesman jailed for 15 years on child sex charges*, 2015). According to AdAge, in 2015 Subway experienced a 10% decline in sales following the suspension of advertisements featuring Fogle. Subway's deployment of a lay person was advantageous in illustrating that dietary changes are realistic and attainable for the average person, thus reinforcing their proclaimed authenticity. However, in 2015, Fogle was sentenced to 15 years imprisonment following charges of child pornography and sexual exploitation (*Former Subway spokesman jailed for 15 years on child sex charges*, 2015). Such Conviction was detrimental to Subway's Brand reliability, as the company's failure to conduct a background check, suggested a prioritisation of profit maximisation rather than the selection of an ambassador who embodied core values (Cawley et al., 2023). Subway is widely recognised for its traditional **television campaigns**

and has underutilised social media platforms as a tool for **integrated marketing communication**. During the Scandal, Subway lacked transparent and consistent communication across all social media and digital channels (Cawley et al., 2023). Consumers inevitably distanced themselves from Subway, perceiving continued support as damaging to their own reputation. Thus, reflecting consumers' self-preservation which ultimately led to the demise of Subway's ethical image as they sought to avoid association with such a scandalous brand.

In addition, Subway attempted to establish brand superiority through a **category extension** into Subway Café, offering premium coffee and pastries (Chamlee, 2016). Despite this, the deviation from its core offering of sandwiches evoked confusion amongst consumers as it contravened its brand identity of accessibility by attempting to reposition itself with a greater sense of prestige (Keller, 2000).

2. Consumer Feelings

Another core component of brand response is consumers' feelings, that is their emotional response to the brand (Keller, 2000). Subway has attempted to elicit feelings of self-respect and social approval by positioning itself as a “healthy alternative” to fast food (Subway, 2023). It is notable that Subway originated in the United States where they notoriously laud standardised and convenient meals. Consequently, consumers may inherently associate Subway's American **origin** with mass market fast food, rather than the minimally processed freshness the brand desires to achieve. In contrast, competitors such as Grill'd have had greater efficacy capturing this market segment. Grill'd was established in Australia, accentuating that Grill'd have leveraged their domestic origin to reinforce an image of non-artificiality and minimally processed ingredients (Meier, 2021). This comparison insinuates that Subway is providing a brand experience that is inconsistent with its identity.

While Subway depicts itself as authentic and aligned with health conscious trends, it is superficial and negligent in acknowledging its country of origin and the stereotypes that fabricate in consumers' minds. Hence, consumers feel limited in their ability to derive a sense of self affirmation from a brand whose core identity is not reflected in their secondary associations (Keller, 2000).

Overall, Subway demonstrates inconsistent performance at the Brand Response stage of the CBBE model. Health perceptions are offset by reputational damage and limited emotional connection. Consumers are confused by the mixed signalling of Subway's secondary associations.

Stage 4: Brand Resonance

Subway has employed **celebrity endorsements** to foster attitudinal attachment. 23-time Grand Slam champion, Serena Williams featured in Subway's Eat Fresh Feel-good commercial campaign, alongside Stephen Curry and Tom Brady. By aligning Serena Williams elite and active lifestyle, it portrays that Subway sandwiches enables individuals to prevail by supporting success, discipline and professional performance (Tennis.com, 2021). Therefore, conveying that Subway transcends beyond healthy eating and is linked to perseverance and aspirational achievement. However, Subway is widely perceived as mainstream, accessible and affordable. Thus, once again there is a mismatch in values, meaning consumers will not believe that Williams genuinely consumes Subway thereby eroding any admiration for the brand as they continually prove to be insincere (Keel & Nataraajan, 2012).

While, Subway has prompted some behavioural loyalty through their reward program, "Subway rewards", to encourage repeat behaviour, this loyalty is transactional for consumers.

Attitudinal attachment precipitates large Behavioural loyalty (Keller, 2000). For Subway, repeat purchases are driven out of convenience rather than admiration.

In short, Subway fails to achieve strong brand resonance. While there are shallow attempts at behavioral loyalty, it is convenience driven, lacking the attitudinal attachment that aids in the development of meaningful long term relationships.

Key Opportunities:

Opportunity 1 :

Based on the CBBE analysis, Subway has a valuable opportunity to strengthen its brand performance by addressing two interconnected problems: operational inconsistency and outdated service models. First, inconsistencies in product quality, service standards, and hygiene across franchise locations have weakened customer trust and diluted the brand's promise of fresh, high-quality food. Second, in today's fast-paced and tech-savvy environment, customers increasingly expect efficient, digital-first experiences. Survey responses and industry trends indicate a growing preference for features like **contactless payments, real-time queue updates, and self-service ordering** which help enhance brand performance through consistency and digital innovation.

Opportunity 2:

Another key opportunity is for Subway to ensure greater alignment of core values with secondary brand associations, enhancing overall brand resonance. Consumers evaluate the

authenticity of a brand based on the consistency between its values and the associations it forms through **events, endorsements and loyalty programs**.

Recommendations:

1. Improving Brand Meaning Through Performance

Subway has performed poorly in the Brand Meaning tier, especially when it comes to Brand Performance. This metric measures how well the product or service meets the customer's functional needs (Keller & Swaminathan, 2019). Differences in product and experience quality across Subway franchises has impacted the brand equity on this level.

To amend this, the first strategic recommendation is to **strengthen product reliability and service effectiveness through** operational consistency to target brand performance. To do this, **tactical actions** include implementing a universal training system. Rouiller and Goldstein (1993) confirmed that training systems for employees in a franchised chain leads to better performance in terms of quality and service. This would involve standardised training modules across franchises that are focused on speed, hygiene, and customer service etiquette. Further, a centralised audit system through the use of internal checks could promote transparent performance tracking. Subway could implement a scoring system and recognise high-performing outlets with incentives or features. Investing in training, especially across franchises ensures a path to success, especially since differences in quality consistency could damage the overall reputation of a brand (Simpson, 2022). Thus, improved operational consistency would contribute to strengthening the brand performance of Subway.

The **second strategic recommendation is to modernise the Subway experience for improved speed and efficiency.** In 2021, it was found that 61% of US customers preferred touchless transactions and contactless payments (Server, 2021). **Digital ordering kiosks** could be installed to reduce wait-time, especially during lunch and other high-traffic periods (Appendix B). Subway's current mobile ordering system could be extended by implementing a real-time queue management system. Overall, the second set of recommendations aims to align every Subway franchise with the overall brand's promise of quality and focus on customer service. By implementing the quality assurance programs and a unified training playbook, Subway can ensure the brand message is embedded in customer interactions, influencing customer experience and loyalty. In doing so, the brand performance will be vastly improved through ensuring service effectiveness and reliability.

2. Improving Brand Resonance

Brand Resonance relates to the relationship between customers and the brand, and the extent to which customers feel they are "in sync with the brand" (Keller & Swaminathan, 2019). The first **strategic recommendation** to improve the brand resonance of Subway will be focused on improving the **behavioural loyalty** of the brand. A **tactical recommendation** centers around revamping the current Subway loyalty program. In 2019, Subway restructured their existing "Eat Fresh Club" loyalty program into the Subcard membership program (Subway Australia, 2019). The system has been appreciated for its tier system, rewarding current habits instead of encouraging drastic purchase behaviour changes (Mobivity, 2024). However since it is falling behind competitor programs that center personalisation, the primary strategic recommendation would be to revamp the rewards system to prioritise **personalisation** and **gamification**. Therefore, customised tasks and achievements based on

purchase behaviour could be implemented to encourage participation. 80% of consumers are more likely to make a purchase when brands offer personalised experiences (Epsilon Marketing, 2018). Tailoring deals and offers to past purchases, such as an in-app cookie promotion using images of the customer's most ordered cookies, can promote an "engaged relationship" (Covello, 2024) between the customer and the brand. A 2020 study found that gamification in branding positively affected brand engagement (Xi & Hamari, 2020). This could be leveraged by gamifying the loyalty program on the Subway app with leaderboards, weekly challenges, etc. Revamping the loyalty program would show that Subway is moving towards improving brand image, giving customers a reason to return by prioritising customer experience.

The aim of the **second strategic recommendation is to strengthen the brand resonance by** creating a sense of **community** around the brand. Brand communities are specialised communities based on a structured set of social relations among admirers of a brand (Muñiz & O'Guinn, 2001). They can facilitate relationships between the customer and a brand, which is a key component of brand resonance in the CBBE pyramid. Subway could consider investing in enhancing the brand community around it through a target marketing campaign. **A "#MySubWay" marketing campaign** could include user-generated Tiktok and Instagram content where customers showcase their own unique Subway orders. These could be featured online and in-store, boosting shared identity. Influencers and creators could collaborate with the brand in competitions such as building "Around the World" Subway orders, or ingredient challenges. This allows for sharing of values, lifestyle choices and Subway preferences. Therefore, after the brand ambassador scandal, a thoughtfully designed loyalty program and marketing campaign can play a key role in rebuilding brand resonance, to create a better psychological connection consumers have with Subway.

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Appendix

Appendix A - Subway Brand Awareness Survey Questions

1. Can you recognize the Subway brand from its logo?
2. Have you eaten at Subway before?
3. When you think of fast food sandwich brands, which ones come to mind?
4. Have you ever seen or heard Subway's slogan, “Eat Fresh”?
5. What three words do you associate with Subway?

Appendix B - Summary of Key Survey Findings

The following summarizes Key survey results (N= 19):

Survey question	Key finding
Logo recognition	100% recognized Subway’s logo
Prior Experience	90% had eaten at Subway before
Brand recall	Over 50% mentioned Subway unpromoted
Slogan Familiarity	42.1% were unfamiliar or unsure about the Eat Fresh slogan
Brand association	Most common: “fresh, healthy.” “Customisable””boring, repetitive”

Brand Performance Summary Table

Performance Area	Subway’s strength	Insight
Product quality	Fresh, customizable, healthy	Strong brand association with “ freshness ”
Reliability	Mostly consistent	Slight weakness in franchise variability
Service	Fast, customizable	Efficient but varies by staff and location
Design and style	Clean, modern	Practical but not emotionally engaging
Price	Affordable	Relatively high cost-performance ratio

Appendix C - Visual Representation of Survey Results

Chart 1: Brand Recognition of Participants

4. Which of the following brands have you heard of?
20 responses

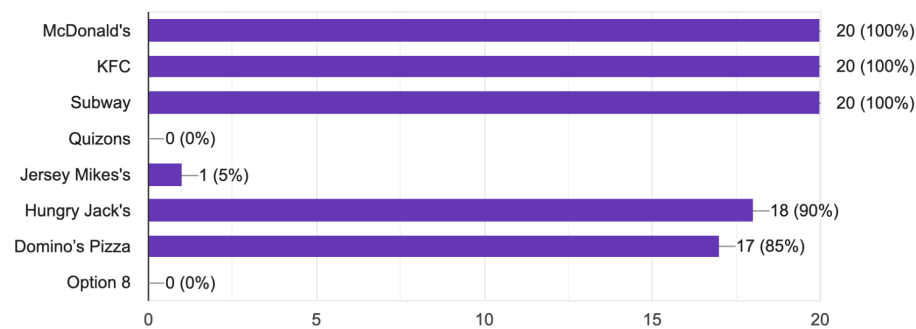


Chart 2: Logo Recognition among Participants

Which of these brands can you recognize based on their logo?

20 responses

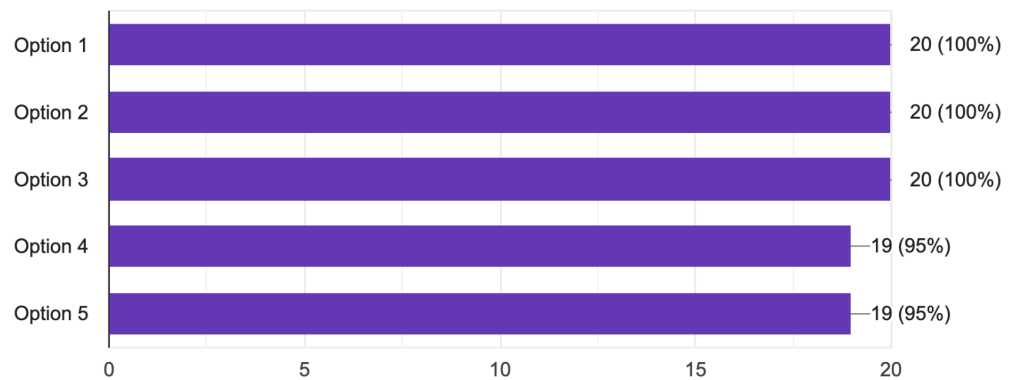


Chart 3: Brand awareness

When you think of fast food sandwich or sub brands, which ones come to mind?

19 responses

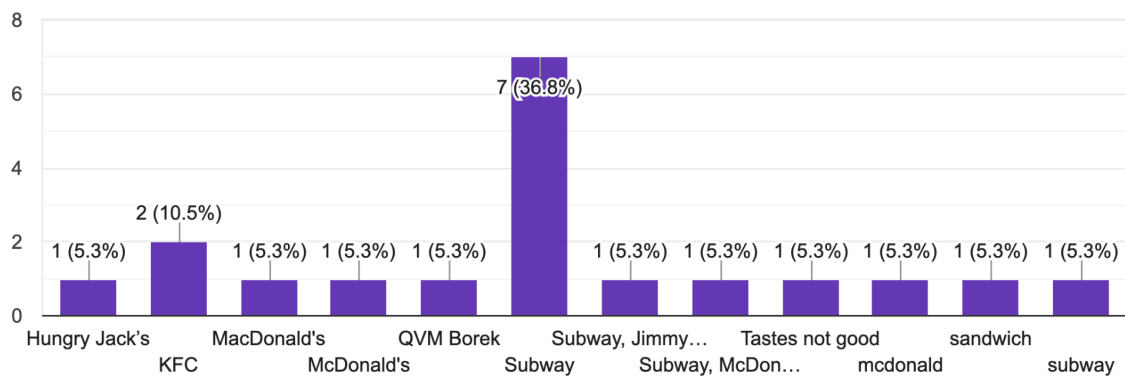


Chart 4: Frequency of eating Subway

Have you ever eaten at Subway?

20 responses

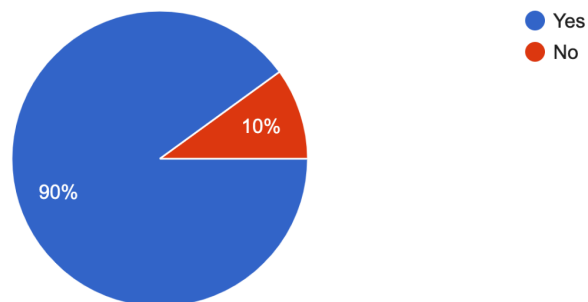
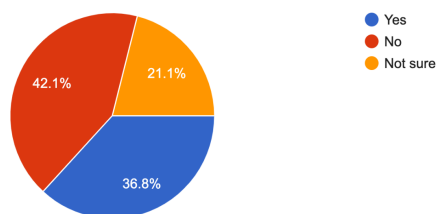


Chart 5: Familiarity with Subway’s Slogan “Eat Fresh”

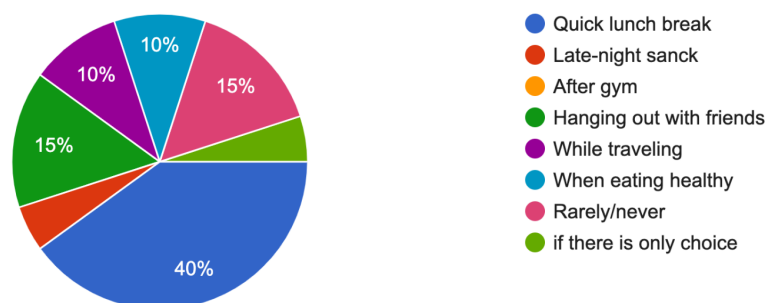
Have you ever seen or heard Subway's slogan, "Eat Fresh"?

19 responses



In which situations would you usually consider eating at Subway?

20 responses



Appendix D- Table 3 – Price Comparison Between Subway and Competitors (2025, Australia)

Item	Subway Price (AUD)	McDonald's Price (AUD)	KFC Price (AUD)
Standard Combo Meal	\$11.50	\$10.95	\$11.30
Chicken Wrap	\$9.00	\$8.50	\$8.95
Salad Bowl	\$10.50	Not available	Not available

Appendix E Subway Australia Ingredient Overview

Breads

Bread Type	Description
White Bread	Classic white bread, soft texture
9-Grain Wheat Bread	Made with whole wheat flour and grains.
Italian Herbs & Cheese	White bread topped with a blend of Italian herbs and shredded cheese.
Multigrain Bread	Contains a mix of grains and seeds for added texture and flavor.

(Subway, 2023)

Appendix F - Ingredient and Menu Comparison between Subway and Competitors

Bread Options

Feature	Subway	McDonald's	Grill'd
Variety	Multiple bread choices including whole grain	Standard burger buns	Variety including low-carb and gluten-free options
Customization	High – choice of bread type	Limited – fixed bun options	Moderate – some customization available

Protein Choices

Feature	Subway	McDonald's	Grill'd
Range	Wide – multiple meats and vegetarian options	Moderate – primarily beef and chicken	Wide – includes beef, chicken, lamb, and plant-based
Customization	High – choose quantity and combination	Limited – fixed burger compositions	Moderate – some customization available

Vegetable Inclusion

Feature	Subway	McDonald's	Grill'd
Variety	High – multiple fresh vegetables	Low – limited to lettuce, tomato, onion	Moderate – standard salad ingredients
Customization	High – choose any combination	Limited – minimal customization	Moderate – some customization available